

Isolated Forested Wetland

PHOTO BY ALAN CRESSLER



RETICULATED FLATWOODS SALAMANDER
(*AMBYSTOMA BISHOPI*) BY ROGER BIRKHEAD

HABITAT DESCRIPTION

Forested wetlands are seasonally or semi-permanently flooded forests of depressional features. These habitats are often not connected by surface streams and depend on rainfall and runoff from surrounding areas. Soils range from mineral to organic and canopy dominants may include bays, gums, pond cypress, and/or pond pine. In the Piedmont, they may include water oak, shagbark hickory, Oglethorpe oak, loblolly, and shortleaf pine. They typically hold water in the spring but could at other times of the year as well.

IMPORTANCE TO FORESTRY OPERATIONS

Forested wetlands in Georgia have historically been prized for their high-value timber, including cypress and other hardwoods, which thrived in nutrient-rich, wet soils. These areas supported important industries such as lumber and naval stores, contributing significantly to the state's early economy.

However, early logging often caused ecological damage—including soil compaction, altered water flow, and reduced regeneration—due to the challenges of harvesting in saturated, sensitive soils.

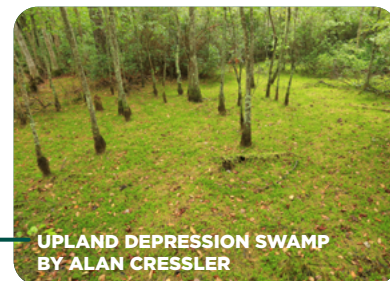
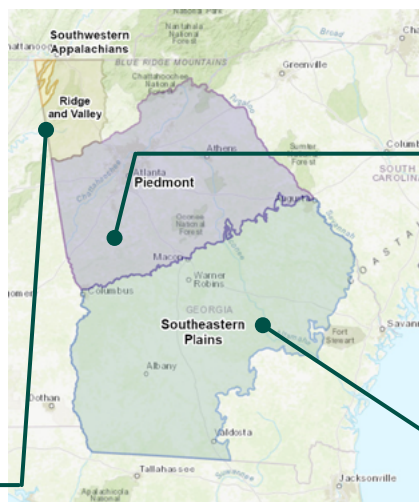
Despite this, forested wetlands remained critical for timber supply and were often converted via ditching and drainage to improve access and productivity for planted forests.

Today, sustainable forestry recognizes the ecological importance of these wetlands, and practices like BMPs, low-impact machinery, and prescribed fire are used to balance timber production with conservation. When managed properly, these wetlands offer restoration opportunities, balancing timber production with ecosystem recovery.

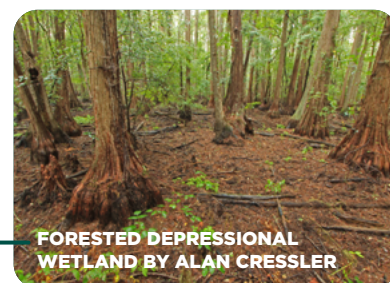
SWAP Priority Habitat	Ecoregion(s)
Forested Depressional Wetlands	Southeastern Plain
Upland Depression Swamp	Piedmont
Sagponds	Southwestern Appalachians/Ridge & Valley



SAGPOND BY ALAN CRESSLER



UPLAND DEPRESSION SWAMP
BY ALAN CRESSLER



**FORESTED DEPRESSIONAL
WETLAND BY ALAN CRESSLER**

THREATS

- Habitat loss, degradation, and fragmentation, including clearing and conversion of habitat to agriculture, and residential and commercial development
- Fire suppression can degrade these habitats by allowing competition from undesirable competing vegetation.
- Alterations to hydrology such as ditching, draining, filling in wetlands, and water impoundments
- Firebreaks, roads, and ruts caused by heavy vehicle traffic interrupt the natural progression of fire, change hydrology, and reduce movement of wildlife.
- Pollution and upstream sedimentation alter hydrology and water quality.
- Overstocked stands can degrade habitat by creating closed canopy conditions and reducing sunlight on the ground.

CONSERVATION MANAGEMENT RECOMMENDATIONS

- Avoid bedding, mechanical site preparation, and other soil disturbance.
- Retire fire breaks and allow fires to burn through these areas when possible.
- Avoid placing roads, drag lines, and firebreaks through these habitats.
- Protect from pollution and erosion runoff from nearby operations.
- Reduce invasion by woody vegetation utilizing prescribed fire on a 2-3-year rotation or with selective spot applications of herbicide if prescribed fire management is not an option.

MORE INFORMATION

Visit Georgia Biodiversity Portal for more information about specific species and habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIABIODIVERSITY.ORG](https://georgiabiodiversity.org)

Georgia's State Wildlife Action Plan has more information about specific management actions to protect these habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIAWILDLIFE.COM/WILDLIFEACTIONPLAN](https://georgiawildlife.com/wildlifeactionplan)

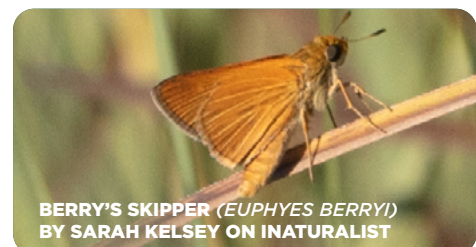
Georgia's Forestry BMP manual is designed to help landowners prevent or minimize impacts to water systems, the manual is available online.

[HTTPS://GATREES.ORG](https://gatrees.org)

View the GA SIC Storyboard for more information and resources



SELECTED PRIORITY SPECIES



See full list of Species via QR code to left